

The power of gunpowder

During the 9th century CE, scientists in China produced gunpowder—the first explosive material. Their invention must have come as a surprise because they were trying to make something quite different. However, the powerful force that they created was rapidly put to use for launching weapons, blowing things up, and creating spectacular displays of noise and color.

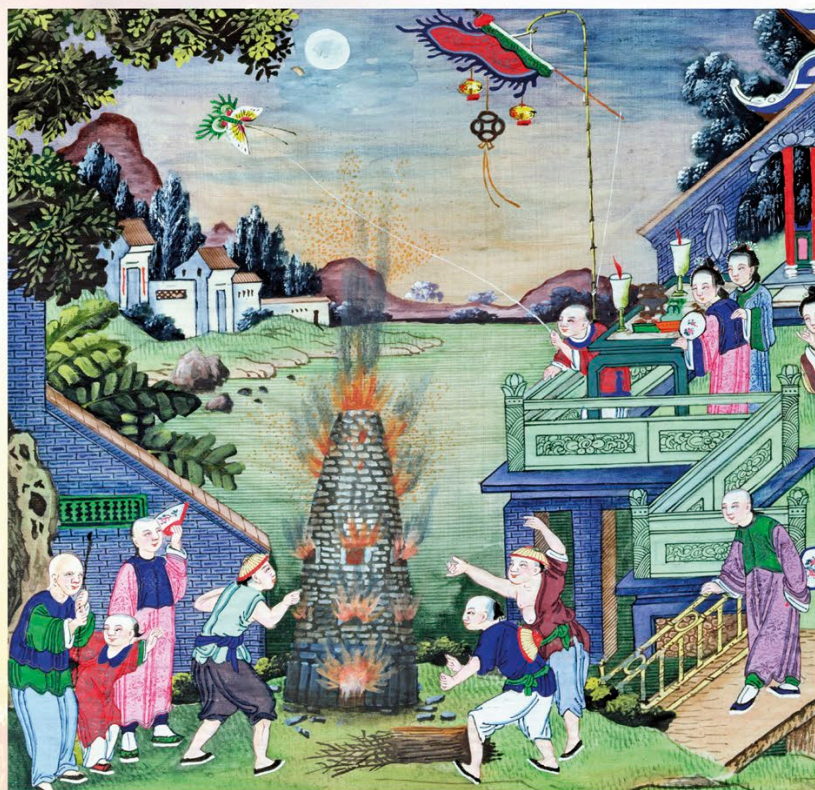
Modern Chinese firecrackers

THE INVENTION OF GUNPOWDER

Medieval Chinese scientists invented gunpowder by accident when they were mixing chemicals together in the hope of finding a life-lengthening potion. The ingredients of the mixture were saltpeter, charcoal, and sulfur.

Within a few decades of its discovery, gunpowder was being used in weapons of war.

Painting of Chinese families enjoying a celebration with fireworks



FIREWORKS

The first fireworks came from China. People simply threw gunpowder into a fire to enjoy bright sparks and loud bangs. The next step was to stuff gunpowder into a hollowed-out bamboo stick and light an attached fuse. When the burning fuse ignited the gunpowder, the tube shot into the air and exploded in the sky, just like firework rockets do today.